

One illustrates what the average wildcatter faced when he jousting with certain major oil companies. The other proves that while some large firms had no compunctions about strangling an independent operator, others were ready and willing to give him a break—and even a helping hand.

As soon as I'd brought in Cleaver Well Number One—

which produced an impressive 5100 barrels a day—I cast about to find a buyer for my crude production. To my dismay, the firms I approached refused to deal with me. The motives behind this evident boycott became infuriatingly clear within a few days, when I received several calls from brokers offering to buy the Cleaver Lease at a very low price. The brokers refused to name the principals they represented.

By then, I was an old hand in the petroleum industry. I recognized all the classic signs indicating a well-organized squeeze play. Certain interests wanted my lease. Either I sold out at a ridiculously low price, or I would be left without any market for the oil produced by the wells on the property.

Unable to sell my oil, I had to find some way to store it.

The only storage facilities available in the Los Angeles area were in a defunct refinery—two storage tanks with a total 155,000-barrel capacity, which I immediately leased. In the meantime, even while I was vainly seeking a buyer for the 5100 barrels of crude my Well Number One was producing

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every 24 hours, Well Number Two came in for a 5000-barrel daily production. This was followed in short order by Number Three, which produced 5100 barrels a day, then by Number Four, the runt of the litter, which brought up 2100

barrels daily. This production rate was rapidly filling the two storage tanks—and I was still unable to find an outlet for the oil. I knew that when the tanks were topped off, I'd have no choice but to shut down my operation entirely.